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Short-Term & Vacation Rental Discussions



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Short-Term & Vacation Rental Discussions

Smart locks with remote control recommendations

Thomas Zamora  **POSTER**

Posted over 6 years ago

Hi everyone, look. I am going to become a host on airbnb, so, trying to set up the house for guests, and I need to know which smart locks are reliable. I found this thread here

<https://www.biggerpockets.com/forums/530/topics/503083-smart-locks-recommendations>

but that's a two-year-old one, and the only brand that is mentioned is Kwikset. I've read some info about Schlage and August. Schlage has some kind of an app that allows you to change the pass remotely. That's the thing I'm looking for. I also found the list of smart locks <https://wisepick.org/best-smart-lock-for-airbnb-more-convenience-less-hassle/>. So, if you have any of those in the list or just you know the smart lock with app for remote control let me know. Google did not help me at all

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Joe Scaparra Investor Austin, TX
Replied over 6 years ago

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Go with August Lock you will be HAPPY you did. Here are the reasons why!

1. The lock attaches to the back of the dead bolt inside the house. No key pad outside, no indication that you are using a smart lock. Your dead bolt still has the key as a back up from the outside it looks like a normal lock.
2. The August lock uses bluetooth and/or WIFI to connect. You control from anywhere through your phone, no need to be WIFI or bluetooth connected can connect through your data plan as well.
3. August lock will integrate with Airbnb if you want to send info to your guest automatically no need to do it yourself, but you can. You can give your cleaners or co-host long term access, your choice.
4. August lock has no subscriptions to pay monthly, unlimited access to as many people as needed, can give temporary access to guest based on there stay time to the hour and minute.
5. Guest and you access through app. If Wifi is down, no problem bluetooth is there as well. If power goes out have lock box with key on the outside of the property for backup.
6. Your welcome!!!!

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John Underwood 🏆 #5 All Forums Contributor Investor Greer, SC
Replied over 6 years ago

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13,422
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I'd like to know the ones that are recommended without any subscription needed vs a subscription. I know from research that the ones that automatically generate a new code for each guests and is just good for their stay seem to require a subscription.

Also which are best for Vrbo vs Airbnb and which ones work well with both. I use both platforms but I use Vrbo the most.

So same question Thomas is asking but with more detail.

John Underwood

⬆ 2 Votes

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4,236
Posts

5,689
Votes

Luke Carl

🏆 #3 Short-Term & Vacation Rental Discussions Contributor

Rental Property Investor Tennessee Florida
Replied over 6 years ago

@Thomas Zamora Remote Lock and August seem to be the most advanced. Although last I heard Remote got bought out and is going away.

There are three systems.

1. An old fashioned key pad deadbolt. Leave the same code for all guests.
2. A hub deadbolt that connects to your WiFi via a hub. Some people love them. Some people have many problems.
3. A subscription based lock that you can change the code from your phone at any time and they'll integrate with Airbnb and change codes for you. (As far as I know big John, there are no locks that integrate with VRBO. VRBO won't allow it).

One year ago the above info was 100% correct but technology is changing all the time so hopefully more people will chime in.

I use method number one. Thousands of bookings and I've never had an issue. I figure after all these bookings and zero issues why should I waste my time changing codes. I prefer to spend as little time as possible on properties I've already acquired. I spend that time looking at properties I don't already own.

*Note..... I've found that the locks only last about 2-3 years before they need to be replaced. Electronics exposed to the elements won't last forever. This obviously won't apply to a condo.

**typed on an iPhone

Luke Carl Podcast Guest on Show #30

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Paul Sandhu 🏆 #5 Short-Term & Vacation Rental Discussions Contributor

Investor The worst town to live in, KS
Replied over 6 years ago

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I go with system #4. A plain entry door knob and a matching deadbolt (optional). It is opened manually with a key. I buy them from Wal Mart for the price of a 12 pack. I install them myself, but some not so bright people on here would probably pay a locksmith to install them. The only thing worth stealing in my STRs is the HDTV, and I've taken steps to prevent that from happening.

But with the price of HDTVs falling, they won't even be worth stealing any more.

⬆ 0 Votes

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Rod Joseph Rental Property Investor Alpharetta, Georgia (GA)

Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

145
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I use Schlage Connect. With a Smartthings hub you can change the code remotely when someone books and deactivate on checkout.

⬆ 1 Vote

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Ruth Blue Realtor Pigeon Forge, TN



Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

230
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111
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We just transitioned over to Schlage Connect this year from the standard keyless entry. It runs smooth and you can have I believe up to 5 locks on one account. Hopefully in the future they will increase that number. When we bought the first ones the Smart hub was a separate device to plug in and sync. Now the new ones are all inclusive. If your ordering off Amazon be sure to use Camel to purchase when the prices are discounted.

👍 0 Votes

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Joey Morea Lender Tampa, FL
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

149
Posts

102
Votes

@Thomas Zamora

Remote lock is the way to go 6 per month per lock. Connect it to the Vera hub and get the York yrd216 deadbolt or the Remote lock CG 7i if you need a lever lock. Integrate it into your Vrbo and Airbnb and when you get a booking it automatically makes a code for the time of their stay and if you want it to will email the guest the code with the check in instructions. Or you can set custom codes. Get alerts when the first time they check in or when the cleaners open the door for cleaning after check ins. I manage two STR out of state and having this info is so helpful. I personally think you open yourself to a big liability risk if you are using the same code or giving guest physical keys where they can make a copy.

👍 0 Votes

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Michael Baum 🏆 #2 Short-Term & Vacation Rental Discussions Contributor
Olympia, WA
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

8,556
Posts

7,449
Votes

Hey @Thomas Zamora. We use the Schlage Smart Connect like @Rod Joseph.

You have to use a smart home hub of some kind. I am currently using a Wink 2, but they appear to be slowly going out of business so I am switching to Samsung Smart Things.

It allows you to remotely change the door codes. Stores up to 32 codes I think which should more than enough.

We are going on our third year and the lock has worked perfectly. It is very efficient on batteries (I change them once a year). You can set alerts and it keeps a log.

... ..

⬆ 0 Votes

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Joe Scaparra Investor Austin, TX
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

662
Posts

1,058
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Go with August Lock you will be HAPPY you did. Here are the reasons why!

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2. The August lock uses bluetooth and/or WIFI to connect. You control from anywhere through your phone, no need to be WIFI or bluetooth connected can connect through your data plan as well.
3. August lock will integrate with Airbnb if you want to send info to your guest automatically no need to do it yourself, but you can. You can give your cleaners or co-host long term access, your choice.
4. August lock has no subscriptions to pay monthly, unlimited access to as many people as needed, can give temporary access to guest based on there stay time to the hour and minute.
5. Guest and you access through app. If Wifi is down, no problem bluetooth is there as well. If power goes out have lock box with key on the outside of the property for backup.
6. Your welcome!!!!

⬆ 3 Votes

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Nancy Bachety Rental Property Investor Sag Harbor, NY



Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

1,010
Posts

626
Votes

We use August smart lock with the connect for two properties. No subscription. Batteries that we change. New code automatically generated with a confirmed booking on Airbnb, not sure about VRBO because I never tried. Our automatic message sent upon booking from iGMS states to look for the email from August and to write down their unique code as a backup. I tell them it is so unique they should not expect us to know it at the last minute.

I don't know about the lock @Joe Scaparra mentions that doesn't look like a keyless lock, but that doesn't bother me in today's day. I'd use it anyway for my kids not needing a key.

0 Votes

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Jessie Leonard New to Real Estate New Braunfels/Canyon Lake TX
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

32
Posts

21
Votes

We use August for all the same reasons @Joe Scaparra mentions above. No subscription, easy to install and it's been very reliable since we have had it. Easy peasey

0 Votes

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Steven Peterson Rental Property Investor Chattanooga, TN
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

7
Posts

0
Votes

@Thomas Zamora We have August in our personal home and it's been great. You can set temporary and proximity passes. You have to buy the wifi connector separately, so the whole system is pretty expensive, but reliable.

0 Votes

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Derek Larson Investor Traverse City, Mi
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

58

Posts

12
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I use the Schlage, with the connect so i can change codes remotely. I can set certain access codes and times for guests, maintenance, or PM. One think I really like about it is that I get a notification when unlocked or locked. I can also check history of what codes were used and when. It was a couple hundred bucks but well worth it- like to get another for my home.

Derek Larson

0 Votes

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Brady Beshear Rental Property Investor Wichita Falls, TX
Replied over 6 years ago

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51
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@Thomas Zamora we just started hosting our first property and I went with the Schlage Smart Connect lock. I also use the Rental Lock Automator from rboys. It is a smart app for the SmartThings hub. My setup automatically assigns a code when someone makes a reservation in Airbnb. No subscription required. I also use smart bsb to automatically send code to guest a couple of hours before checkin. So far, this has worked great!

0 Votes

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Jeffery Wilen Rental Property Investor Vancouver, WA
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

181
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115
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► Originally posted by @Joe Scaparra:

All of the above from Joe and August also can provide notifications of door usage or you can check it from the app.

0 Votes

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Michael Sjogren Investor Beverly, MA
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

103
Posts

70
Votes

[@Thomas Zamora](#) If you plan to have 10 or less go with August, it is extremely user friendly and integrates directly with Airbnb & VRBO so each guest automatically gets their own unique code which only works during their reservation and automatically expires. If you have more than 10 DM me and I'll walk you through my system.

0 Votes

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Brian G. Rental Property Investor Los Angeles, CA
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

1,829
Posts

1,242
Votes

[@Derek Larson](#) how do you set time sensitive codes with Schlage Smart Connect? Via a hub or with the Schlage app or...? I don't think you can do time sensitive codes with a Smart Things hub. Is that correct [@Rod Joseph?](#)

0 Votes

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Rod Joseph Rental Property Investor Alpharetta, Georgia (GA)
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

145
Posts

68
Votes

[@Brian Gerlach](#)

Schlage does not do time sensitive codes out of the box. I believe you will have to use a third party app for that like RBoy app.

0 Votes

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Derek Larson Investor Traverse City, Mi
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

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12
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@Brian Gerlach. The adapter that hooks to my WiFi. Then I go through Schlage app- once I have code created. I can go to schedule and adjust from there. Like cleaners just access on Friday's. Or recently the furnace guy. Created new code and it was only good for Monday. I still have to delete the code later or it would be good for next Monday too. But joe criminal or opportunistic doesn't know that- Incase they tried to come back next day or whatever.

Hope that made sense and helps. Wanted to try and post screen shot.

Derek Larson

0 Votes

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Brian G. Rental Property Investor Los Angeles, CA
Replied over 6 years ago

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@Rod Joseph do you need an adapter of any kind for Smart Things v 3 out of the box to connect to Schlage Smart Connect lock or do you simply need the Smart Things Hub and the Schlage lock? Do you program your codes via Smart Things App or Schlage App? Are the codes date sensitive or do you program a code which then becomes active and delete it later? @Derek Larson what adapter and hub are you using?

0 Votes

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Cliff H. Rental Property Investor Nashua, NH
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

583
Posts

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Hi @Thomas Zamora. Welcome the forums and the new investment journey. I spent much time looking at most of the major locks/hubs/systems on the market and for locks I highly recommend taking a look at the [Schlage Connected Keypad line](#). The reason for this that they integrate with nearly any of the remote-connected systems and they don't try to mechanically open locks/deadbolts themselves, but rather just activate/deactivate the ability for the user to manually twist the handle/deadbolt themselves. This is a subtle, but significant distinction.

Most smart locks in the product category (August included) are trying to use batteries to physically move a deadbolt in/out of a door jamb when they receive a remote command or local user code.

Unless you have a perfect door jamb and minimal temperature fluctuations, most of the mechanical smart locks on the market today are a recipe for short battery life and lock jams that leave your property unsecured. As a host I also spend a huge amount of time patronizing other vacation rentals as well and am always appalled at the level of issues around basic lock function I encounter in rentals where I know the owners are hundreds of miles away.

For me, the combination of the Schlage Connected Keypad line, SmartThings hub, and the Rental Lock Automator app turns a \$400 initial investment into a fully-automated system that allows me to think beyond the lock and start imagining new and better ways of ensuring a great guest check-in experience. Things like ensuring temperature's set exactly right, lights are all on, and relaxing music is playing when a guest opens the door. Logistically the three pieces work together to do the following:

- Auto-generate codes for every AirBnB, HomeAway, Booking, TripAdvisor guest I have that are easy for guests to remember because they're generally based on their phone number or arrival times.
- Auto activates/deactivates codes before/after guests' check-in
- Triggers user specific actions/automations for any number of other devices, switches in the property.
- Removes any need for ongoing subscription, monthly fees, or additional costs
- Set it and forget it lock management with codes pushed to the lock so that pre-programmed codes continue to work, even if the hub/connection falls offline

Cliff H.

⬆ 1 Vote

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Julie McCoy Real Estate Agent Sevierville, TN
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

[@Thomas Zamora](#) I've been using RemoteLock at my VRs and they do everything I want them to do - connect via wifi WITHOUT a hub, direct integration with

1,088
Posts

1,568
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AirBNB and VRBO, every guest gets a unique code that only functions for the duration of their stay. I can control the codes and access times from my phone. Yes, there's a subscription, but at \$6/mo I can handle it.

What happens if wifi goes out? Well, unless wifi is out from the time the guest books to the time they check in, there's no problem - because the guest info is sent to the lock immediately after booking and stored there. It still functions fine if wifi is down for awhile. Because of this system - it's not constantly connected to wifi, it just "touches base" once an hour (or at intervals you set) - battery life is pretty solid, and I'll get alerts if batteries get low/I can monitor battery level from the app.

Things I don't love about it: the online interface feels old-fashioned and is somewhat unintuitive. They keep changing the way they integrate with VRBO so I have to stay on top of that. The physical buttons on the lock don't always respond on first push (if you don't push firmly enough).

But, they've done a great job for me across four properties, and I haven't seen

0 Votes

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Cliff H. Rental Property Investor Nashua, NH
Replied over 6 years ago

User Stats

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► Originally posted by [@Julie McCoy](#):

Thanks for sharing your experience with RL Julie. From the sounds of what you're describing this is similar to the way the SmartThings and RBoy apps work as well: push the code to the lock on a initial booking, activate it on X schedule, then push a command to delete code on end of their stay. I haven't tested it to see if the hub still pushes the command to the lock if the Internet drops out, but since most of these systems are all operating over a standard Z-wave protocol, I suspect they would.

I've looked into some other home automation setups that are fully local (no hub), but am equally as uncomfortable with those options since you'd still want some form of backup for the configuration, similar to way security teams used to move closed circuit security video recordings off-site for archival/backup purposes.

Cliff H.

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